# A Rhetoric of Argument

**Brief Edition**
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Jeanne Fahnestock
*University of Maryland*

Marie Secor
*Pennsylvania State University*

McGraw Hill

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## Audience

Every argument is addressed to someone, even if that someone is only an aspect of oneself. Audiences vary greatly in size, from the single conversational partner to the worldwide television audience of 2 billion for the Olympics, from the handful of readers interested in a professional article to the thousands of hits on a popular web site. Audiences also vary in nearness and accessibility. The speaker before a small group can see if someone in the audience looks confused or has fallen asleep. Student writers learn, sometimes too precisely, what the teacher as audience thinks of their papers. Flaming e-mailers may be quickly singed with a response. But there is one difference in kind of audience that we need to examine more closely, the difference between listeners to a spoken argument and readers of a written argument.

Because the writer's audience is so different from the speaker's, and because this book primarily concerns written argument, we need to think about the special circumstances of the writer's audience. First, though some forms of writing, like the editorial to the citizens of Indianapolis, are targeted to specific readers, writers have no absolute control over who will pick up their texts or when. Second, in all writing situations, the "now" of the writer is never the "now" of the reader. The writer can never make moment-to-moment adjustments to the perplexities and gleams that cross a reader's face. Third, the writer can rarely be sure of the reader's background information or interest in a topic. For these reasons, Plato distrusted writing and made Socrates complain, "once a thing is committed to writing it circulates equally among those who understand the subject and those who have no business with it; a writing cannot distinguish between suitable and unsuitable readers. And if it is ill-treated or unfairly abused it always needs its parent to come to its rescue; it is quite incapable of defending or helping itself" (*Phaedrus*, translated Walter Hamilton. London: Penguin, 1973, p. 97).

Because of the distance in space and time separating writer and reader, written arguments have special constraints. Writers have to work harder to imagine and anticipate audience reaction since they will not see or hear it as speakers do. Writers may have to explicitly address a smaller group among their readers since they cannot turn toward them as a speaker can. Writers sometimes become less "time bound" in their references if their piece is supposed to be read in the coming years and not just in the coming days. But even though some pieces of writing seem to address anyone at any time, all arguments are always addressed to an audience. There is an "other" out there, and that possibility of an audience affects every choice that an arguer makes.

## Exigence

All arguments have another requirement, one so obvious that it is almost invisible. Arguments need a reason to exist. We do not just begin to make a case to another person unless we have a reason to make one and we can convince the other person or persons that they have a reason to listen. Often that reason is a problem that needs to be solved (what candidate to choose) or an event



that needs to be responded to (an accident), or a circumstance that requires speech (a wedding toast). Furthermore, there must be some forum and occasion like a town meeting, or some demand and deadline like a research paper assignment, to bring the argument into existence. In other words, there must be some push in the circumstances and some way to respond to that push. The combination of these factors creates what can be called *exigence*.

In order to appreciate the need for exigence in argument, think of the need for appropriateness in everyday conversation. Imagine a very imperfect stranger stopping you in the street and forcefully detaining you with a harangue on an absurd topic like the merits of plastic toothpicks. You would assume the stranger was drunk or insane to speak to an unknown person at an inconvenient time about an irrelevant subject. Our irritation with such uncalled-for discourse reveals the social requirements for appropriate communication. We instinctively assume that communications addressed to us have a purpose, even if that purpose is maintaining friendships. In the same way, we expect arguments addressed to us to justify their demands on our attention—in other words to have exigence.

### Exigence in Writing

In speaking situations, where the factors of time and place are powerful and inescapable, exigence is easy to understand. On the day of your "retro" party, you walk into a store and ask "Do you sell toothpicks?" and the salesperson launches into a discussion of the merits of plastic over wood toothpicks. Perfectly appropriate.

But in writing situations exigence can be harder to invoke. You could not write an essay on plastic toothpicks for a general circulation magazine without giving people a reason to want to read it. To compensate for the greater separation of writing from its audience and occasion, a written argument must frequently create its own exigence. It must give its readers a reason for reading, an answer to their fatal question "So what? Why should I be reading this? Why should anyone care about what this writer cares about?"

To solve the exigence problem, writers can always try to put their texts in the hands of only interested readers. The writer of the editorial that opens this chapter knew that its argument addressed to Indianapolis voters was going to appear in an Indianapolis newspaper. Furthermore, the editorialist could take advantage of timeliness to create exigence. The editorial urging readers to vote appeared on the very day of the election.

Without the possibility of such direct appeals to the features of an immediate rhetorical situation, writers can also try less direct means to construct reader interest. They can, in effect, preface their main argument with a mini-argument about its importance, interest, curiosity value, significance, and so on. To do so they find some feature in their material that links to the known interests and concerns of their audience. The writer with plastic toothpicks to sell may appeal to the nostalgia of an older audience or the desire to awaken interest in the styles of the 1940s in a younger audience. A clever writer can construct exigence for almost any case.